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Source criticism for cultural history

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ABSTRACT

Source criticism has been used for various scholarly purposes since the late eighteenth century. History as a science has changed significantly since then and historians of the twenty-first century use different sources than previous generations. Looking at teaching materials for history studies, the method of analysing textual sources does not appear to have changed in the last 150 years. However, a critical assessment of source criticism for cultural history will reveal the implicit and explicit changes to the method as well as possible points of further development. The article begins with a brief overview of the steps of source criticism as a method of historical research (heuristic, source analysis, interpretation, presentation). Its application to early modern diplomatic correspondence as an example of textual sources leads to a reflection on source criticism as a method for cultural history. Although the formal analysis of a textual source may remain the same, today's cultural historians are interested in different questions than earlier generations, leading to different interpretations. The final step of the historical method – the presentation – remains largely unreflected, even by cultural historians; it needs to be rethought and redeveloped in the future in order to truly reflect the aims of cultural history.

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Introduction

Particularly in the early days of a cultural approach to historical research in the 1990s, one fault line of academic discourse was the use of sources. Although historical anthropology had already demonstrated an extensive use of textual sources, methodological differences arose, even concerning the concept of sources themselves, with cultural historians stressing the use of 'historical material' instead of 'historical source' to indicate the larger scope of sources used and questions asked by cultural history (Landwehr 2013). In this article, I argue that we as cultural historians are in fact modifying the methods of source criticism to apply them to

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different historical materials, questions, and topics relevant to cultural history, but often do so without reflecting on how we are conducting research.

Digital humanities have also changed the approach to sources, with an increase in published editions of sources over the last decades, online databases replacing printed source editions or presenting digitised versions of such editions, databases of digital images of printed texts or scans of archival material, all with or without transcriptions. Text-mining and similar approaches help to ask and answer new questions in considering large corpora of textual sources (Graham, Milligan, and Weingart 2016). Digital history may indeed offer a truly new methodology for historical research. Recent developments include the possibility to automatically transcribe handwritten texts with a very low error rate by using software (Transkribus), thereby allowing unprecedented insights into sources previously only accessible in archival reading rooms (Huysman 2017, 2020).

However, considering sources as the basis for historical research, for historiography, cultural studies, or the humanities in general, is nothing new: 'ad fontes' – back to the sources – has been an imperative of historical research since the humanist period, with renewed emphasis since the nineteenth century as part of a renewed interest in biblical studies and the hermeneutical analysis of the Bible. The German so-called Tübingen School of biblical scholarship became dominant in the first half of the nineteenth century, and its methods also influenced biblical studies in the English-speaking world (Bowie 2018). At the same time, as history became an academic subject and focused largely on textual sources, academic historians adopted source criticism as a method of historical research in general (Ranke 1874).

History as a discipline has changed considerably since then, and historians of the twenty-first century use different sources than earlier scholars, but the method of analysing textual sources seems to have changed little in the last 150 years – or at least that is the impression one might get from looking at today's textbooks published as introductions to history and source criticism (e.g. Rhode and Wawra 2020, 20–30; Burger 2022). But it remains questionable whether cultural historians really use the methods and techniques of the nineteenth century.

Cultural history might be a way of understanding symbols, images, encounters, negotiations, and translations, the diversity of human culture, and past lives in general (Burke 2008, 3–4; 2012, 9). But Peter Burke already noted some years ago that 'the frontier between social history and

cultural history has become difficult to locate' (2012, 3) and indeed most fields of historiography – political, social, legal, economic, or diplomatic history – are also considered from a cultural point of view, for example, the 'new diplomatic history' or the 'cultural history of diplomacy' (e.g. Mössland and Riotte 2008). Burke therefore suggests that cultural history should not be understood as a separate field, but rather as a way of writing history from a particular point of view (Burke 2012, 7). Aware of the fact that cultural history has thus become the umbrella term for a number of very different approaches to historical research, I will continue to use 'cultural history' in this way throughout the article.

In this article, I will first analyse source criticism as a type of analysis of textual sources used in historical research. A brief overview will show the steps of source criticism as a historical method and its historical development. In order to provide a clearer outline of the method, this part will be based on published versions of university lectures and textbooks, with a focus on German publications. Secondly, I will ask how cultural historians can use source criticism today. To illustrate the steps and the uses of source criticism, I will look at diplomatic correspondence as a substantial example of early modern correspondence. By choosing this type of early modern written sources, this article will also contribute to the cultural-historical approach in diplomatic history.

While the formal analysis of a textual source may remain the same, cultural historians are interested in different questions than, for example, historians interested only in political history. By looking at the steps of source criticism, it will be made clear that the interpretation of these sources by cultural historians is consequently very different. Furthermore, cultural history offers new ways of presenting research than those that were acceptable in earlier decades.

Developing source analysis

History became an academic discipline in Germany, as in other European countries, in the nineteenth century. Very early on, the focus was on sources: The *Monumenta Germaniae Historica*, founded in 1819 for identifying and editing textual sources on German history, was only the first of many German projects on sources and source editions (Bünz 2019, 15–36). One of the first to use source criticism in German scholarship was the historian Barthold Georg Niebuhr (1776–1831) (Heuß 1981). Even more influential was Leopold Ranke , who, from the 1830s onwards,

introduced courses on reading sources as a standard part of the study of history . The methods he taught were those of the Tübingen School, originally developed for theology and philosophy and especially used by biblical scholars for the critical reading of biblical texts (Harris 1975).

Some thirty years after Ranke's lectures, another German academic historian, Johann Gustav Droysen (1808–1884;1983), gave his first lecture on the methods and theories of history, an area of historical teaching he called 'Historik'. Recognising that source criticism was a necessary element of historical research, Droysen further developed this method and taught it in his lectures on history and historiography at the University of Jena; he later published these lectures in a small volume of 84 pages (Droysen 1868). The lectures had only a small audience, but the publications had a much wider reach (White 1980, 76). Droysen expanded the book slightly to about 100 pages for three editions in the following decades (Droysen 1868, 1868, 1875, 1882). A fourth, revised edition appeared in 1925 (Droysen 1925). To date, there are about 20 further editions in German, including several critical editions.

The 1868 edition of Droysen's *Historik* contains about fifteen pages on the 'method' of historical studies, presenting a structured way of working with sources (9–25). Droysen thereby offers a controlled way of producing historical knowledge. The historical method itself consists of four steps: heuristic, source analysis, interpretation, and presentation. Although these four parts are presented independently, they are meant to be intertwined, resulting in a continuous back and forth between the different steps (Bernheim 1889).

Droysen's work was also known outside of German-speaking academia, especially from the 1882 edition (Droysen 1882a). A French translation appeared as early as 1882 (Droysen1882b, 1892), and later critical French, Italian, and Spanish translations have been published (Droysen 1966, 1983, 1967, 2002). Indeed , in the brief introduction to *Outline of the Principles of History*, Droysen himself states that the reprinting of 1882 was triggered by '[n]umerous requests, some of them from foreign lands . . .' (Droysen 1897, ix). Elisha Benjamin Andrews, who translated Droysen's work into English with the author's consent and published it ten years later in 1893, noted that '[i]n real grasp upon the nature and meaning of history he [=Droysen] seemed to me the superior of Ranke'. Andrews, who expanded on Droysen's highly abbreviated explanations to make them more accessible, found Droysen's emphasis on 'the understanding of history' and his methods

of analysing sources in this regard as more important than the contemporary norm of 'gathering facts' without 'reflect[ing] upon their deeper meanings' (Droysen 1893, viii).

More important for the long-term dissemination and influence of Droysen's methods in German-taught history studies was a much larger standard textbook for history students written by Ernst Bernheim (1850–1942) and first published in 1889 (e.g. Bernheim 1889; Ogrin 2012). Bernheim expanded Droysen's short explanations into a book of over 500 pages. Bernheim's work was very influential especially because of its many editions until the 1940s and thus its wide distribution among generations of German history students. But Bernheim was also noticed outside of Germany. The Danish historian Kristian Erslev (1852–1930), for example, based his 1911 textbook on historical methods, *Historisk Teknik*, on Bernheim (see, e.g. Edelberg and Simonsen 2015, 218; Erslev 1911). Erslev used the German textbook and a comparable French volume to explain how European scholars used the historical method (Langlois and Seignobos 1898).

Bernheim continued to revise and expand his book, bringing it to over 600 pages already for the second edition in 1894, and to over 800 pages for the sixth edition in 1908. The length of the book allowed him to explain in detail the steps of historical studies, the 'character' of history as a field of scientific research, and the historical method (Bernheim 1894, 1908).[1] He also included extensive observations on the sources and collections of textual sources available at his time, on the auxiliary sciences of history, and on the classification of types of sources; these were topics only hinted at byBernheim (1894).

However, despite Bernheim's importance for the spread of the historical method, Droysen and his *Historik* were rediscovered in the second half of the twentieth century. The philosopher Gadamer praised his modern hermeneutics, and historians such as Jörn Rüsen rediscovered Droysen's methods and his historiography. Indeed, Rüsen's interpretations of Droysen have greatly influenced the reception of the historical method since the 1970s, suppressing Bernheim's importance in favour of Droysen (e.g. Rüsen 2013). Such a new critical edition of Droysen's *Historik* caught the attention of Hayden White. He was struck by Droysen's insistence on 'historical reading', which he called 'original': 'He [=Droysen] instructs historians in how to produce different readings of history so as to engender different kinds of moral perspectives in their readers, but reconciling them with respect to the current social system and its doxa in every case' (White 1980).

Source criticism in teaching

Based on Droysen's ideas, source criticism as a standard historical method is still taught in many university history courses. Discussions with fellow historians suggest that this is the case in Austria, Denmark, Estonia, Finland, and Germany, to name but a few. The following description therefore goes beyond the nineteenth-century text to include today's teachings. Interestingly, the method is not regularly taught in anglophone countries, nor is it reflected in textbooks on source reading (e.g. Laura and Willis 2016), which only discuss different groups of primary sources and various current topics of research. The German historian Philipp Müller, in a chapter on hermeneutics and source criticism, offers an overview of the history of the method without discussing its application (2020, 21–36.).

The first step in this method, called heuristic, is to develop a guiding question for one's research and to assess whether the topic and the question are relevant to historical studies (Droysen 1868, 13–15; extended to nearly 50 pages in Bernheim 1889, 153–201). Based on the question, the researcher then searches for suitable sources. As a historian of ancient history, Droysen included not only textual sources but also all kinds of material sources , comparable to modern cultural historians. The two processes of searching for sources and clarifying as well as modifying the guiding question are interdependent, a reciprocal process that continues until the research has been presented as the final step of historical research. For example, historical materialism as the communist historiography analyses history as a series of revolutions: therefore, the questions asked, and the sources used (heuristic) as well as the understanding of historical events (interpretation) differ from other forms of historiography.

In the source analysis, the second element of source criticism (Droysen 1868, 16–19; Bernheim 1894, 202–390), the sources are first analysed to determine whether they are genuine – that is, unaltered and not forged – material, which can be done by testing the paper or material in general, the ink, the writing, and so on (e.g. Hylkema et al. 2015). The historian must also consider whether the sources are valid, i.e. relevant, to the question. This first part of the source analysis is also called the 'external source analysis'. The second part, the 'internal source analysis', answers first of all the questions about authorship (by whom), intended recipients (for whom) and date (when), followed by cause (why), content (what), and structure or narrative (how).

The third part of source criticism is the interpretation of the source(s) (Droysen 1868, 19–22; Bernheim 1894, 391–510). For Droysen, the main method of interpreting any text or historical event was the hermeneutic approach. He sought to understand the past by assessing the way of thinking, the intentions, and the significance and meaning of events for contemporaries. In the *Historik*, he proposes four different approaches: a pragmatic interpretation, which looks for causality, or cause and effect in history; an interpretation of the conditions, which looks at space, time, resources (geography, chronology, materials); a biographical interpretation which sees human action as the result of character and behaviour; and an interpretation of ideas, according to which events or actions express the concepts or ideologies of any given historical period. Hayden White compares these with psychological, causal, teleological, and ethical interpretations of the later twentieth century (White 1973, 270). The French school of Annales, and social and economic history in general, use sources such as statistics, accounts, and figures, which require analytical rather than hermeneutical interpretation. Other interpretations – as well as questions and sources – have been introduced by women's and gender history, the history of concepts, and cultural history, which will be discussed later in this study.

Historical research does not end with the interpretation of sources or events. Rather, the results must be presented to an audience, which is also the final step of Droysen's historical method. Without *presentation*, the results of research remain 'unripe and undisclosed' (Droysen 1868, 22–25; Bernheim 1894, 511–528). Compared to the other sections, this part is very short in Bernheim's book; this may be the reason for its neglect by later generations. As Hayden White has pointed out, Droysen insisted that historians could not determine the historical truth, but only determine what was plausible. He therefore stressed the importance of historical representation, 'the historian's production of an image of the past and of a discourse capable of assimilating that image to the reader's understanding (White 1980, 83–84)'. The historian's task, then, is to explain the past and point out reflections of the past in the present.

To present the results of research, it is possible to choose between different forms in terms of the structure or aim of a presentation. One form is an investigative structure, which follows the guiding question and describes how the analysis was conducted, thereby offering an understanding of the historian's decisions during the process of source criticism. In Droysen's time, and also later on, a narrative form of presentation was the most common; historiography had to 'tell a story'

to be acceptable to the audience. The most important work on this aspect of nineteenth-century historiography remains White's *Metahistory* (White 1973). Especially in school teaching, but also for wider audiences, the aim is ofte to 'learn from historical events', which means to adopt a didactic approach. History is then seen as the 'teacher' of humanity. Probably the most common form of academic writing is discursive, offering insights into the discourses and deliberations about historical facts and figures. A discursive presentation helps the historian to participate in historiographical controversies.

Later historians and teachers of historical methodology mostly presented only the first three parts of source criticism: heuristic, analysis, and interpretation. Rüsen only mentions representation as part of the historical method in a very short paragraph (Rüsen 2013, 188). However, he adds a long chapter on 'topic', i.e. forms and processes of historiography, (191–219), which , however, is not part of his explanation of the historical method. Pandel mentions four parts, but these are 'the historical question', 'heuristic', 'analysis', and 'interpretation' (Pandel 2006, 180). Implicitly, the narrative and investigative presentations became the most common forms of writing historical results. Interestingly , however, the presentation as the fourth step of source criticism is rarely mentioned when discussing the historical methodology or Droysen's work (Möhler, n.d.).

When students of history or historical subjects are asked about source criticism, most of them assume , firstly, that source analysis (the evaluation of sources according to standard questions) can be used as a 'recipe' for all kinds of sources (which may be true), secondly, that source criticism according to the standard of heuristic, analysis, and interpretation is the only way to assess sources in history (which might not be true), and thirdly, that this is all there is to Droysen (if they know the name at all) and his methodological work. However, in everyday scholarly work (i.e. in analysing sources), most students (and the same is true of professional historians) will never even think about the way they work with sources, but will do so 'instinctively'. Such instincts will, in the long run, be shaped by criticisms received and by reading history written by others (e.g. Burger 2022, 114–115).[2]

Applying source criticism in cultural history

In order to understand the needs and challenges of source criticism for cultural history, examples will be taken from one type of early modern

written sources. However, the findings could be elaborated by using other sources as well. Diplomatic correspondences, i.e. instructions, reports, relations, and letters as different types of diplomatic sources, can be defined by their authors, the circumstances of their production as well as their contents.[3] The authors of such texts were monarchs or heads of state, foreign ministers, secretaries of state, diplomats, and other persons involved in foreign relations and diplomacy who wrote about negotiations, exchanged knowledge about foreign courts, or deliberated on policy in terms of personnel, topics, terms, and so on. In addition, the private correspondence of these actors adds to the picture provided by the official documents, especially with regard to working and living conditions.[4] For historical research since the nineteenth century, such diplomatic sources have been (and sometimes still are) mainly used to determine 'who said what to whom, when and where'. This type of use prevailed until the mid-twentieth century (e.g. Gibbs 1962; Steuer 1957). But for cultural historians, while it is still important for them to know the sequence of events and the persons involved, other information contained in diplomatic sources is of much greater interest. In the following section, I will show how the heuristic, analysis, interpretation, and presentation of diplomatic sources change when they are used for cultural history.

For cultural history, the question of 'who said what to whom and when' and its results, such as a source-based sequence of events and contents of negotiations, are only the basis of historical research. Regarding the **heuristic** as the first step of source criticism, a cultural historical perspective considers much broader questions about early modern diplomacy. In general, cultural historians are interested in people's lives and the background of their decision-making. But every person active in any given situation is also understood to fulfil different roles in relation to the others with whom they interact, the place and time, the aims of the action and so on. This is why cultural historians speak of 'actors' and their roles. A very common approach to actor-centred research on early modern diplomacy is Hillard von Thiessen's concept of diplomacy of the *type ancien*, according to which diplomatic actors were part of patronage and family networks that influenced their decision-making (Thiessen 2010a). His concept has also been taken up by international scholars (e.g., Hennings and Sowerby 2017, 7).

To determine one actor's status in relation to another, a closer look at the visual elements of letters can be useful, as the format of early modern diplomatic letters follows epistolary forms: This means that the blank

margins reflected the status of the person addressed in the letter, becoming larger the higher the rank of the addressee. Letters were folded and sealed to prevent them from being opening undetected (envelopes were not yet common), a method called letterlocking (Dambrogio 2014).[5] The style of writing, in terms of address and language as well as calligraphy, was also linked to the different ranks of author and reader (Furger 2010).

Texts were intended for different audiences and therefore labelled differently, especially in the later early modern period since the seventeenth century (the following classification is based on my own research). These labels can denote different uses in terms of information exchange, the inclusivity as well as exclusivity of courtly, political, or diplomatic circles, and the circulation of knowledge in general. A report without any difficult content was classified as 'open' and was circulated among officials but could also be shown to foreign diplomats. 'Secret' or 'very secret' letters contained critical information that needed to be protected from public scrutiny or could potentially damage diplomatic relations. Some parts of secret letters could even be encrypted to prevent a wider readership (Auer 2015). The open and secret parts of letter contained proven information, descriptions of important events, accounts of conversations and deliberations, and suggestions for possible future actions to be taken. Letters marked 'private' might contain similar or the same information but were intended for a limited readership – most often the king or queen and their minister(s), and sometimes the members of the council or other advisors (Backerra 2018, 43). In this sense, at least in the eighteenth century, private meant 'limited' (either in terms of access or intended readership). A letter could be 'Secret' and 'private' at the same time, indicating both the importance of the information (secret) and the limited number of readers (private). A distinction was made between this use of 'private' and the idea of a 'private' letter between family members or friends, containing very personal or intimate details. These letters were usually written by the author him- or herself (rather than by a secretary), and on a different, thinner, and smaller sheet of paper. Over the course of the early modern period, diplomatic letters thus became standardised in terms of format and content.[6] Knowledge of this standard helps to structure their subjects and to identify any deviations from the norm in terms of format or content.

Content wise, attention has been drawn to the importance of ceremonial instructions. Research especially in the last two decades has shown that conflicts and negotiations over ceremony and ritual, far from being 'unimportant squabbles', were in fact central to a society based on

symbolic language and with a strong hierarchical structure (e.g. Krischer 2009; Stollberg-Rilinger 1997). Court ceremony demonstrated, reinforced, and determined the relative rank of actors (Backerra and Edwards 2021, 2–5). Ceremonial questions made up about half of the instructions written for diplomats sent abroad (Charles VI, Emperor, 1728). In this respect, the question of who made the first formal visit to another person showed the differences in rank between diplomats at a foreign court. The imperial envoy to London, for example, was therefore instructed to first make informal visits to the houses of other ambassadors(especially those of Spain and France) and then to insist that these ambassadors visit his house formally first, in order to show the imperial precedence (Charles VI, Emperor, 1729).

Other questions raised by cultural historians in relation to early modern diplomacy concern the use and influence of urban and rural spaces, notions of foreignness and familiarity, secrecy or privacy, inclusivity and exclusivity, confessional beliefs, mentalities, concepts of nationality, borders, and the use of languages, gifts, and favours, the negotiation of power as well as diplomatic knowledge in general and the circulation of knowledge specifically. Interest in these topics is a result of various turns in the humanities and the social sciences, e.g. the linguistic turn, the performative turn, the spatial turn, or the knowledge turn (e.g. Bachmann-Medick 2016; Jordheim and Gary Shaw 2020).

Besides 'official' sources such as instructions, relations, and reports, a letter from a diplomat's family member or friend (Mills 1731/35) or a hand-written newsletter (Gulston 1786)[7] could be used to analyse the topics mentioned above. Private letters concerning diplomatic relations were mostly exchanged between actors of the same rank and could include remarks on family, friends, and relations, humorous or tragic life stories, funny or interesting side facts, weather news, pleasures, illnesses, complaints, etc. (Backerra 2018, 44–45).

With the development of cultural history, scholars started to use literary sources for historical research (e.g. Braubach 1969). Poetry, plays, and novels often reflect political, social, and other developments of a society. Even more than with 'traditional' sources, however, it can be difficult to determine whether such a source is genuine and valid for one's research (e.g. Georgi et al. 2015).

To establish a diplomat's network, newspaper articles as further textual sources can be used to show his social activities. The imperial envoy and later ambassador stationed in London, Count Philipp Kinsky (1700–1749), never mentioned anything specific in his relations and the other

surviving correspondence about his network in London. But a newspaper noted that he visited a well-known sports club, Figg's, to practise sword fighting (Boulton 1901, 28), and another describes a ball given by Kinsky at Somerset House in London to celebrate the marriage of Archduchess Maria Theresa and Duke Francis Stephen of Lorraine (The Monthly Chronologer 1736). A billet for the most important amusement park of the time, the Vauxhall Gardens, of 'His Excellency Ct. Kinsky' has survived as well; as 'Excellence' was the title used by ambassadors, not envoys, the token was issued in 1733 at the earliest, after Kinsky had risen to that diplomatic rank. The token, which could have been purchased at the time by anyone with the financial means, therefore shows that Kinsky paid to have access to the festivities at Vauxhall, and may have used the gardens for socialising (Kleisner 1999, 33–35). This token has survived as part of a collection of medals and tokens in Prague; it is likely that Kinsky took it with him as a souvenir when he returned to his native Bohemia. In a letter from a lady of high society to a friend, Count and Countess Kinsky and their foreign guests are mentioned: during the summer months, the Kinskys spent time at their country house and visited the members of the elite, were invited to dinners and balls and participated in fairs and dances (Croker 1824, 373–374; Dyrmann 2021). Participation in such activities was the norm in European diplomatic circles.

The structure and methods of **source analysis** remain largely the same, no matter which approach is taken to historical research. The linguistic turn, however, added another layer of analysis concerning the narrative and structure of a source as well as the analysis of formal textual structures in relation to issues of gender, rank, identity, political, social, and economic status. The language used in correspondence is noteworthy in this respect; it was a means of conveying or asserting status. In the diplomatic and dynastic correspondence between the courts of Vienna and London, for example, letters in Italian by the emperor and the imperial family and in French by the king and the royal family are part of the relations of Emperor Charles VI with King George II of Great Britain and of Ireland. Letters in German exchanged between the same rulers are part of the correspondence of Emperor Charles VI and George as George Augustus, the Elector of Brunswick-Lunewick and vassal of the emperor in the Holy Roman Empire (e.g. Backerra 2018, 268–273). Similarly, in the first half of the eighteenth century, full powers and letters of accreditation were still usually written in Latin as the universal European language. However, because the Court of Vienna used a ceremonial diminutive in the translation of titles given to crowned heads

(replacing 'maiestas' with 'serenitas'), the British envoy to Vienna received an additional set of letters in French, which would be answered in the same language – then with the title 'majesté' (George and King of Great Britain and Ireland 1727).

The approaches to **interpretation** suggested by Droysen were very general. Pragmatic interpretation with its search for cause and effect is, of course, still used in cultural history, but the question of why someone did something is emphasised. It is determined, for example, by the role played by any given actor in the moment being analysed. The framework of actions becomes more complex the more concepts and ideas are included. If borders are understood as constructed concepts, the crossing of borders – be they political, social, or geographical – and the use of space discussed in the sources raises further questions. A newspaper article from 1730 reports that Baron Waldegrave, the British envoy, rented lodgings in the so-called *Freihaus*, a complex of buildings just outside of the city limits marked by the fortifications, and that his successor, Sir Thomas Robinson, moved into the same lodgings in 1730 (Anonymous 1730). The Freihaus – in English 'free house' – was owned by the Starhemberg family, whose senior was a member of the Secret Conference, the imperial privy council (Czeike 2004, 390–91). The article therefore suggests, on the one hand, that diplomats had the help of senior government officials in finding accommodation. On the other hand, since the Freihaus was outside of Vienna, it was also outside the confessional restrictions and the tax limits imposed on the imperial residence. As diplomats of a Protestant power in a Catholic territory, Waldegrave and Robinson were responsible for providing for the spiritual needs of their compatriots in Vienna and the surrounding area, which was easier outside of the official city limits (e.g. Anderson and Backerra 2020). The same is true for other concepts and experiences; even a weather report might then be interesting. Waldegrave wrote to a friend in 1728: '[. . .] I never knew what Cold was, till I felt it here, Every thing is frozen up, and I am told that this is but a beginning' (Waldegrave 1728). However, at the time, the diplomatic relations were equally cold and negotiations frozen (Backerra 2018, 65) so, in this context, Waldegrave describing the start of a cold winter in Vienna is likely related to his experience of failure as a diplomat.

Psychological interpretation of history is often difficult. Thomas Otte calls it the 'missing "personality dimension"' of international history, which also applies to diplomatic history (1997, 9). Rather than being seen as true reflections of character, emotional displays and descriptions

of behaviour are scrutinized as constructed performances, which were as much a reflection of an actor's political and cultural origins and their rank and status as of the observer's own background and dependences (e.g. Backerra 2018, 293–297). A further path for early modern diplomatic history opens up with various insights offered by the history of emotions (e.g. Lazzarini 2015, 213–238).

Instead of the idea of the 'nation' in the nineteenth century , the most influential concepts for cultural history for interpreting early modern diplomacy have been confessionalization (Schilling 2007), state-formation, and especially bureaucratisation, professionalisation and institutionalisation (Braun 2018), dynastic politics and dynastic rule (Kampmann 2013; Osborne 2002), gender (Bastian 2013), mentalities and political culture (Strohmeyer 2007).

Historians often do not reflect on the final step of source criticism: **presenting** the results of analysis and interpretation according to the chosen research question. Writing or speaking about the results of the analysis of textual sources seems to be a largely instinctive decision based on personal preferences and historiographical traditions. In British historiography, chapters often follow a chronological structure with specific analytical categories addressed in each part of the chronology. In other historiographies, for example in German, French, or Spanish, books and other forms of writing are often structured only according to analytical categories, perhaps with a contextualising chapter on chronology of events. Other forms of presentation follow the sources, talking about one source after another. While narrative forms of presentation are still common in many historiographical traditions, have for a long time been disdained, for example in French historiography, which focuses on deconstructing past narrative storytelling (e.g. Ondoua 2016), and in German historiography, because German cultural history set out to abolish any 'master narrative', whether hermeneutically or analytically framed (Rüsen 2020, 100). Recently, however, some examples of fictional, but fact-based narrations from a cultural historian's point of view have been included in German publications (Tantner 2011). In publications in other languages, this method has been used even decades ago (Ginzburg 1976; Schama 1991), but I have not yet found any examples of this form of presentation in works on diplomatic history. However, a narrative style is often used in general historical works, filmed documentaries (or 'histotainment') and publications intended for a wider audience. Another issue related to formal style, language, and historiographical traditions is the use of 'I' or 'we' or simply neutral expressions in

historiographical writing. As cultural historians, we are indeed called upon to clearly state our point of view – but most often, because we follow the examples presented to us since the first day of our studies, we exclude ourselves from the presentation and hide behind a generalised language.

Conclusion

This article has presented the ideas behind the development of the method of source criticism in the nineteenth- and twentieth century and its general outline. Diplomatic textual sources have served as an example of the application of this method to textual sources and the changes brought about by cultural history. These include new research topics and questions and various formerly disregarded types of texts. However, as this article has shown, a cultural approach changes the method of source criticism only in some respects. Source analysis as the second step remains largely unaffected by changes in theoretical approaches, and the same is true of interpretation and presentation, although new topics, questions, and different sources naturally change the outcome of research. While cultural history is widely regarded as avant-garde in terms of theory, it operates with an established, although partly adapted, methodology in terms of source criticism. This tension between theory and methods is particularly evident when it comes to source criticism. Future research will show whether there can be a new and/or adapted form of presenting historical research, befitting the theoretical advantages of cultural history.

Notes

1. From the 3rd edition onwards, Bernheim published his book under a slightly different title: *Lehrbuch der historischen Methode und der Geschichtsphilosophie: Mit Nachweis der wichtigsten Quellen und Hilfsmittel zum Studium der Geschichte* (Bernheim 1903, 1908).
2. I am thankful for the participants of the Enlightenment Reading Group to discuss this point openly and frankly, and also wish to thank an anonymous reviewer for further commenting on this point.
3. See Cathleen Sarti's article on source genres in this collection.
4. The praxeology of diplomatic reports is the claimed focus of an edited collection by Dorfner, Kirchner, and Roll (2021), but, as Marian Füssel pointed out in his commentary, the chapters are 'normal' case studies of diplomatic history with only loose links to praxeological methods (e.g. Füssel 2021, 160–165).

5. Jana Dambrogio and the Unlocking History Research Group filmed such a reconstruction of letterlocking (2016). The newest method virtually reconstructs a letter without unfolding it (Dambrogio et al. 2021).
6. By the eighteenth century, a formal letter by a diplomat (= relation) would include most of the following parts: a salutation or address, an acknowledgement of letters received (with type of mailing/courier's name), a list of letters sent before the current letter, accounts of meetings with heads of state, ministers, other diplomats, then reports of policy making (laws issued, decrees, etc.), details of policy discussed at the court, in the city, or in the political community, and additionally rumours (with an assessment of their validity) as well as general or private remarks on the diplomat's life. The letters ended with a (formal) salutation and address. A letter of instruction (= rescript) by a minister (in the name of a head of state or monarch) would contain much of the same, but also praise or scolding for the diplomat's actions, explanation of politics or policy making, and orders for future conduct (Backerra 2018, Wien und London, 44–45).
7. In his hand-written newsletter on foreigners in London, Gulston (1786) also noted private events such as the birth of children: 'Kinsky, the Lady of Count Ambassador from the Emperor was safely delivered of a son, London, April 1734'.

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